



AL MAAREF AMERICAN SCHOOL

MAS Wellbeing Policy

ACADEMIC YEAR

2026 – 2027

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At Al Maaref American School, we are committed to promoting and supporting the Well-being of every individual through creating a whole school ethos in which the whole community (children, staff, parents and caregivers) feel secure, know that they are valued and are encouraged in their learning, growth and social development and recognize how important mental health and emotional well-being is in our lives. Individuals are better prepared for learning when they are healthy, safe and happy; therefore, Well-being is the responsibility of the whole school community. This policy aims to provide an overview of what Well-being is and the systems and procedures in place to support the Well-being needs of our children and staff.

The School Leadership Team recognizes that: “to help their children succeed, schools have a role to play in supporting them to be resilient and mentally healthy.” Schools can be a place for children and young people to experience a nurturing and supportive environment that has the potential to develop self-esteem and give positive experiences for overcoming adversity and building resilience. For some, the school will be a place of respite from difficult home lives and offer positive role models and relationships, which are critical in promoting children’s Well-being and can help engender a sense of belonging and community.

At Al Maaref American School, our role is to ensure that children can manage times of change and stress and that they are supported to reach their potential or access help when they need it. We also have a role in ensuring that children learn about what they can do to maintain positive mental health, what affects their mental health, how they can help reduce the stigma surrounding mental health issues, and where they can go if they need help and support.

Our Well-being vision:

We aim to promote positive mental health and Well-being for our whole school community.

1. Aims and Objectives

Our aim is to help develop the protective factors which build resilience to mental health problems and to be a school where:

- All children are valued.
- Children can talk openly with trusted adults about their problems without feeling any stigma.
- Positive mental health and well-being are promoted and valued.
- To ensure Al Maaref American School provides a safe, secure, supportive, and stimulating environment that is responsive to the personal, social, and emotional needs of all members of the school community.
- To encourage cooperation, respect, and consideration for and among all school community members.
- To promote warm and positive relationships between children, staff, and parents. • To build an atmosphere of trust.
- To help children and staff grow in self-esteem, confidence, and independence of thought.
- To provide children and staff with opportunities to develop their resilience and coping strategies.
- To encourage the children and staff to value one another and respect the views of other community members.

- To prepare the children for the opportunities, responsibilities, and experiences of adult life. •
- To provide staff with opportunities to develop professionally and personally.
- To promote a community where bullying is not tolerated.

2. Definition of mental health and Well-being

Every individual realizes his or her own potential, can cope with the normal stresses of life, can work productively and fruitfully, and is able to make a contribution to her or his community”.

Mental health and Well-being are not just the absence of mental health problems. We want all children/young people to:

- feel confident in themselves.
- be able to express a range of emotions appropriately.
- be able to make and maintain positive relationships with others. •
- cope with the stresses of everyday life.
- manage times of stress and be able to deal with change. •
- learn and achieve.

In addition to children’s well-being, we recognize the importance of promoting staff mental health and Well-being.

The Well-being program at Al Maaref American School aims to develop the following underpinning skills of Emotional Intelligence to maximize opportunities for individuals to succeed in today’s curriculum and beyond:

- Self-Awareness
- Managing feelings •
- Motivation
- Empathy
- Social Skills

As a High-Performance Learning School, it is essential to develop these aspects of learning within the primary curriculum as:

- They enable us to be effective learners.
- They enable us to get on with other people. •
- They enable us to be responsible citizens.

Well-being is a set of systems, procedures and programs which involve the whole school community and aim to promote High Performance Learning Values, Attitudes, Attributes, and Emotional Intelligence. In an Emotionally Intelligent organization or community, individuals are more likely to work together as proactive and supportive members of a team. Therefore, it is essential to include systems and procedures that enable staff and parents to feel valued and listened to so all stakeholders can work together to promote an ethos that supports the totality of the needs of our children. This enables all children to feel safe, secure, and happy, which in turn prepares them to learn effectively and equips them with the skills to cope with life.

Well-being support for the children is provided at a whole class, a group, or an individual level. Extra support is provided through the periodic “listening lounges”, where individuals or groups of children are given the opportunity, during break times, to talk to the specific Well-being team members about issues they are having, who then offer life coaching in order to address their concerns.

3. Equal Opportunities

The school seeks to achieve a diverse school community that includes people from differing backgrounds with different skills and abilities. The school will take positive steps to create a school culture through its governing body, managers, and other employees, in which people can feel confident of being treated with fairness, dignity, and tolerance, irrespective of their individual differences.

This commitment extends to the whole school community and others connected with it. The school is committed to the elimination of unlawful discrimination and the promotion of good relations between all.

4. Parental involvement

Parents are responsible for sharing with the school any changes in circumstances within the home that may affect the well-being of their children. If children require additional support for their social and emotional well-being, this will be discussed with parents through each step so that the school and home are working together to support the needs of the children.

5. The Role of the Counselor

Counselors and Well-being support staff should have appropriate knowledge of how to communicate with and support all members of the school community and demonstrate an understanding of various circumstances.

The Well-being team will support students who are emotionally vulnerable, including those who have been affected by various global, regional, or personal crises such as COVID-19. Any incident that has had a negative impact on a student’s emotional health and well-being will be supported by the support staff.

Schools shall develop staff and student Well-being plans based on their individual risk assessments in conjunction with school counselors.

6. Roles and responsibilities, including those with specific responsibility

We believe that all staff have a responsibility to promote positive mental health and to understand protective and risk factors for mental health. Some children will require additional help, and all staff

should have the skills to look out for any early warning signs of mental health problems and ensure that children with mental health needs get early intervention and support that they need.

All staff are given a workshop on the possible risk factors that might make some children more likely to experience problems, such as physical long-term illness, having a parent with a mental health problem, death, and loss, including loss of friendships, family breakdown, and bullying.

They should also understand the factors that protect children from adversity, such as self-esteem, communication, and problem-solving skills, a sense of worth and belonging, and emotional literacy (see Appendix 1 Risk and Protective factors).

Our Well-being Team works together to ensure that they lead and support Social, Emotional & Mental Health needs of the community.

They:

- Lead and work with other staff to coordinate whole school activities to promote positive mental health and well-being.
- Provide advice and support to staff and organize training and updates.
- Are the first point of contact with mental health services and make individual referrals to them.

We recognize that many behaviors and emotional problems can be supported within the school environment or with advice from external professionals. Some children will need more intensive support at times, and there is a range of mental health professionals and organizations that provide support to children with mental health needs and their families.

7. Sources of relevant support include:

- Our Senior Leadership Team.
- Our Safeguarding/Child Protection Officer •
Our School Counselor
- Our Learning Support Coordinators help staff understand their responsibilities to children with special educational needs and disabilities (SEND), including children whose mental health problems mean they need special educational provisions.
- Our School Nurse/ Doctor
- Our Student Well-being Leader

At Al Maaref American School, all members of the school community are responsible for supporting the Well-being of children, staff, and parents. Class teachers are ultimately responsible for the social and emotional well-being of the children in their class. They need to set up systems within their classes whereby emotional support is available. This may be through circle time, worry boxes, or other ‘talk’ time systems. If class teachers feel children need further support, they are to discuss this with parents, supervisors, counselors and then seek support from the section Principal.

Supervisors and student counselors are responsible for sharing with the class teacher any concerns they may have when working with the children.

Our Senior Leadership Team is responsible for supporting the class teachers in promoting the well-being of the children at Al Maaref American school.

8. Identification of Well-being needs for individuals and the community

Our identification system involves a range of processes. We aim to identify children with wellbeing and mental health needs as early as possible to prevent things from worsening. We do this in different ways, including:

- Analyzing behavior, exclusions, visits to the medical room/school nurse, attendance, and sanctions.
- Staff report concerns for individual children to the relevant lead persons.
- Worry boxes in each corridor for children to raise concerns which are checked by the student counselor.
- Regular meetings for staff to raise concerns.
- Parental meetings.
- Enabling children to raise concerns to any member of staff.
- Enabling parents to raise concerns to any member of staff.

9. Monitoring Effectiveness of Well-being programs

Various tools are utilized to ensure that individuals and the MAS community are comprehensively addressing needs. To monitor the effectiveness, the tools that are used are:

- Stakeholders Wellbeing Surveys.
- Wellbeing Action Plan.
- Wellbeing Committee minutes of meetings.

10. Staff Well-being

At Al Maaref American School, staff Well-being is treated with the same importance as student Well-being. A supported, valued staff team is fundamental to a healthy school culture and directly impacts the quality of teaching, learning, and care provided to students.

The school supports staff Well-being through the following structures and initiatives:

- A dedicated Well-being check-in embedded within the annual Staff Appraisal process, allowing staff to raise concerns confidentially with their line manager.
- Regular staff Well-being events and activities throughout the school year (e.g., wellbeing days, staff outings, and recognition initiatives).
- Access to confidential support and signposting to appropriate services for staff experiencing personal or work-related stress.
- Manageable workload planning, clear communication channels, and induction/onboarding support for new staff.
- Opportunities for professional development and growth, recognizing that professional confidence contributes to personal Well-being.
- An open-door culture where staff are encouraged to raise concerns with the Well-being Team, Human Resources, or the Senior Leadership Team without fear of stigma.

Line managers and the Senior Leadership Team are responsible for monitoring staff workload and morale, and for escalating concerns to the Well-being Team or Human Resources where additional support is needed.

11. The Well-being Team

The Well-being Team is the coordinating body responsible for leading, monitoring, and evaluating Well-being provision across the school community. The team meets regularly and reports to the Senior Leadership Team on the implementation and impact of this policy.

The Well-being Team is composed of the following members:

- Well-being Lead / Coordinator – oversees the implementation of this policy and chairs Well-being Team meetings.
- School Counselor(s) – provide direct student support and coordinate individual and group interventions.
- Student Well-being Leader – supports the day-to-day delivery of student Well-being initiatives.
- Safeguarding/Child Protection Officer – ensures Well-being concerns with a safeguarding dimension are appropriately escalated.
- Inclusion/Learning Support Coordinator – represents the needs of Students of Determination within Well-being planning.
- A representative from the Senior Leadership Team – provides strategic oversight and links the team to whole-school decision-making.
- A staff Well-being representative – gathers staff feedback and represents staff interests in Well-being planning.

The Well-being Team's responsibilities include leading whole-school Well-being activities, reviewing survey data and the Well-being Action Plan, providing advice and training to staff, and acting as the first point of contact with external mental health services and referral pathways.

12. Links with the Inclusion and Safeguarding Teams

Well-being, Inclusion, and Safeguarding are closely interconnected, and this policy operates alongside the school's Inclusion Policy and Child Protection and Safeguarding Policy. The Well-being Team works in close collaboration with both teams to ensure that concerns are identified early and referred to the most appropriate support pathway.

This collaboration is reflected in the following practices:

- The Safeguarding/Child Protection Officer sits within the Well-being Team and is informed of any Well-being concern that may indicate a safeguarding risk, in line with the Child Protection and Safeguarding Policy.
- The Inclusion/Learning Support Coordinator liaises with the Well-being Team to ensure that Students of Determination receive Well-being support that is adapted to their individual needs.
- Where a student's Well-being needs relate to a special educational need or disability, the Well-being Team and Inclusion team jointly contribute to the student's Individual Education/Support Plan.
- Any concern raised through Well-being channels (e.g., listening lounges, worry boxes, staff reports) that meets the threshold for a safeguarding or inclusion referral is passed on immediately using the school's referral procedures, and is not held solely within the Well-being Team.
- The three teams meet periodically to review cases requiring cross-team input and to ensure a consistent, joined-up approach to student and staff support.